



Video scripts

Nine lessons without a recording, written to match the four that have one.

Nine of the thirteen lessons have no video. These are the scripts for them, written to match the four already recorded.

What they were matched against

The recorded four run 2:11 to 3:40 and carry three or four checkpoints each. Their titles all take the form "Watch: <the question the video answers>". The voice is second person, leans on dollar figures a student can picture, and never explains a term without immediately using it in an example.

These scripts target about 3 minutes, roughly 430 words at a normal speaking pace. Each one is built around three or four beats, and the beats are marked [CHECKPOINT] so the questions can be written once the recording exists.

How to use one

1. Record it. Presenter is whoever is on camera; the existing four are Alvin Lee.
2. Upload to YouTube. Unlisted is fine. The ID is the part after watch?v=.
3. Paste the real transcript with timings into a session, and the checkpoint questions plus their at : seconds get written from it. Do not set timings from this document: the marks below are where a beat *lands in the script*, not where it lands in a recording, and the two will not match.
4. Add the video section to src/content/lessons/<slug>.ts three times, once each for English, Spanish and Chinese. Same videoId, same at : values, translated question text. See STATUS.md for the exact shape.

House rules that apply here as everywhere: no em dashes, no emoji.

Watch: Where Your Money Actually Comes From

365 WORDS · ABOUT 2:26 SPOKEN

Most people think there is one way to make money. You work, you get paid, done. There are actually two whole categories, and knowing the difference changes how you think about every job you will ever take.

Earned income is money you work for. You show up, you do something, you get paid. Unearned income is money your money makes while you are asleep. Interest in a savings account, dividends from a stock, rent from a property you own. Almost everyone starts with only earned income. The goal over a lifetime is to build some of the other kind.

CHECKPOINT · EARNED VS UNEARNED

Earned income shows up in three flavors. Wages pay you by the hour, so 20 hours at \$15 an hour is \$300. Salary pays you a fixed amount for the year no matter how many hours it takes, which is great some weeks and brutal in others. Commission pays you a cut of what you sell, so a car salesperson making 3 percent on a \$30,000 car earns \$900 on that one sale.

CHECKPOINT · THE THREE FLAVORS

So what actually moves your number? Four things. Education, because more training usually opens higher-paying doors. Seniority, because the person who has been there six years knows things the new hire does not. Skills and experience, which is the one you have the most control over right now. And the economy itself, which nobody controls. When an industry is booming it pays more, and when it is not, it does not.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT RAISES YOUR PAY

Here is the part that surprises everyone on their first payday. The number on your offer letter is not the number that hits your bank account. That first number is gross income, before anything comes out. What lands in your

account is net income, after taxes, after Social Security and Medicare, after anything you signed up for like health insurance. The gap is often 20 to 30 percent.

So when someone offers you \$20 an hour, do the math on what you will actually take home before you plan how to spend it. Read your paystub every single time. That is where your money went, itemized, and it is the only place you will catch a mistake before it costs you.

CHECKPOINT · GROSS VS NET

Watch: Every Choice Has a Price

398 WORDS · ABOUT 2:39 SPOKEN

Somebody hands you \$50 right now. You can buy the shoes you have been watching, split it across three smaller things you also want, or put it straight into savings. There is no right answer. But every one of those choices costs you the other two, and that is the whole idea behind smart money decisions.

Economists call it opportunity cost. It is the value of the thing you gave up. Buying the \$50 shoes does not cost you \$50, it costs you the concert ticket you did not buy. That reframe is small and it changes everything, because now you are comparing two real things instead of comparing one thing to a number.

CHECKPOINT · OPPORTUNITY COST

There are three tools that make this easier. The first is comparison shopping, which is not just checking two prices. It is checking price, quality, warranty, and what the thing actually costs to keep owning. A \$40 pair of headphones that dies in four months is more expensive than an \$80 pair that lasts three years.

The second is a cost-benefit analysis. Write the costs on one side and the benefits on the other. Not in your head. On paper, or in your notes app. Half the time the decision makes itself the moment you see it written down.

CHECKPOINT · COMPARISON SHOPPING AND COST-BENEFIT

The third is delayed gratification, and it is the hardest one. Waiting 24 hours before any purchase over some amount you pick, maybe \$30, kills a shocking number of buys you would have regretted. The urge is real and it is also temporary. Companies design checkout flows specifically to get you before it passes.

CHECKPOINT · DELAYED GRATIFICATION

Now use the same tools on financial services, because a bank is a product too. Say EasyBank has no minimum balance and no monthly fee, but only 12 ATMs in your whole city and an app that crashes. SecurePlus has a \$5 monthly fee, ATMs everywhere, and a better app. Which is better? Depends entirely on you. If you withdraw cash twice a week, \$60 a year buys you a lot of convenience. If you never touch cash, you just found \$60.

That is the pattern. Name what you are giving up, compare real options against each other rather than against nothing, and give yourself a beat before you commit. Do that consistently and you will not make perfect decisions. You will make defensible ones, which is the actual goal.

Watch: Turning "Someday" Into a Number and a Date

369 WORDS · ABOUT 2:28 SPOKEN

Fast-forward fifteen years. Where are you living, what are you driving, what are you doing on a Tuesday? Most people have a picture. Almost nobody has a plan, and the difference between those two is entirely about specifics.

"I want to save money" is not a goal. It is a mood. A goal is specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound. Watch what happens when you fix that sentence: "I want to save \$600 for a laptop by June 1st by putting away \$50 a month." Now you know if you are on track or behind, and you know it every single month instead of finding out at the end.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT MAKES A GOAL SMART

Once you have a few goals, you have to rank them, because your money cannot go everywhere at once. The order that works for almost everyone is the same. Emergencies first, then debt that is actively costing you, then everything else.

An emergency fund comes first because without one, the first flat tire turns into credit card debt and undoes months of progress. Start with \$500. That single number handles most of what actually goes wrong in a teenager's life.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT COMES FIRST

Then attack high-interest debt, because a credit card charging you 24 percent is a hole you cannot save your way out of. Paying that down is a guaranteed 24 percent return, which is better than almost anything you can invest in.

After that you can spread out. Save for the car, the trip, the deposit on a first apartment. Long-term retirement money starts here too, and starting at 22 instead of 32 is worth hundreds of thousands of dollars later.

CHECKPOINT · HIGH-INTEREST DEBT

The last piece is milestones. Certain things are coming whether you plan for them or not. A first car, moving out, tuition, insurance in your own name. Writing down roughly when each one arrives turns them from emergencies into line items. A \$2,000 used car in three years is \$56 a month. Nobody panics about \$56 a month. Everybody panics about \$2,000 in a week.

Plans change constantly, and that is fine. The point is not predicting your life correctly at seventeen. The point is that when something changes, you are adjusting a plan instead of starting from nothing.

Watch: How to Spot a Scam Before It Costs You

385 WORDS · ABOUT 2:34 SPOKEN

An email lands in your inbox. First National Bank, official logo, and it says your account has been locked. Click here to restore access. Your heart rate goes up a little, and that reaction is the entire point of the message.

That is phishing. Someone pretending to be an organization you trust, to get something out of you. Usually your password, sometimes your money, often both. And it works on smart people constantly, because it is not testing intelligence. It is testing whether you are in a hurry.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT PHISHING IS

Every scam leaks the same tells. Urgency, because a real bank does not give you four hours. Threats, because fear stops you from checking. An email address that is almost right, like security at first-national-bank dot co instead of dot com. Requests for information a real company already has. And any payment in gift cards, which no legitimate business on earth will ever ask for.

If two or more of those show up at once, stop. Do not click, do not reply. Open a new tab, type the company's real address yourself, and log in the normal way. If something is genuinely wrong, it will be waiting for you there.

CHECKPOINT · THE RED FLAGS

You are not on your own here. The Federal Trade Commission takes scam reports and goes after the companies behind them. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau handles banks, lenders, and debt collectors. The Better Business Bureau tracks complaints so you can look a business up before you hand over money. Reporting takes about five minutes and it is how patterns get caught.

CHECKPOINT · WHO PROTECTS YOU

The worst version of this is identity theft, where somebody uses your name and Social Security number to open accounts you never asked for. You often find out months later, when a card you never applied for shows up on your credit report.

Three habits prevent most of it. Use a different password everywhere, because one leak should not unlock your whole life. Turn on two-factor authentication so a stolen password alone is useless. And check your credit report once a year for free, which is the fastest way to catch an account with your name on it that you did not open.

Being careful is not the same as being paranoid. Slow down, verify separately, and never let someone else's urgency become yours.

Watch: Where Did My Paycheck Go?

393 WORDS · ABOUT 2:37 SPOKEN

You worked 40 hours at \$15 an hour. That is \$600. You already spent it in your head. Then the deposit lands and it says \$478, and your first honest reaction is that somebody made a mistake.

Nobody made a mistake. \$600 is your gross pay, which is what you earned. \$478 is your net pay, which is what you keep. Everything between those two numbers is sitting on your paystub, itemized, and most people never read it.

CHECKPOINT · GROSS VS NET

Start with income tax withholding. Instead of hitting you with one enormous bill every April, the government takes a slice out of every check as you go. You are paying the same tax either way. This just spreads it out so it does not wreck you all at once.

Next is FICA, and this one confuses everybody because it is not really a tax on you so much as a subscription you are enrolled in. It is 7.65 percent of your pay, split between Social Security and Medicare. Your employer quietly pays the same amount again on your behalf. That money funds retirement and health coverage for people who are retired right now, and one day it funds yours.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT FICA IS

Then there is the form that controls all of it, the W-4. You fill it out on day one and then forget it exists. It tells your employer how much to withhold. Get it wrong in one direction and you owe money in April. Get it wrong the other way and you handed the government an interest-free loan all year. Neither is a disaster, but it is worth a look after any big life change.

CHECKPOINT · THE W-4

Here is the habit almost nobody has. Read every stub. Check the hours against what you actually worked, check the pay rate, check that a raise you were

promised actually showed up. Payroll errors are common and they are almost never malicious, but they also do not fix themselves. The person most likely to catch one is you, and only if you look.

At the end of the year all of this gets summarized on a W-2, which is what you use to file your taxes. Keep it. And if you had tax withheld but earned very little, filing is often how you get that money back.

Your paystub is not paperwork. It is a receipt for your own work.

Watch: How Tax Brackets Really Work

388 WORDS · ABOUT 2:35 SPOKEN

Almost everything you have heard about tax brackets from a relative at a family dinner is wrong. The most common version goes like this: "Careful, if you make one more dollar you jump a bracket and take home less." That is not how it works, and believing it has talked real people out of real raises.

Start with what taxes actually buy. Roads, public schools, firefighters, food safety inspections, the military, and the bridges you drive over without thinking about it. You can argue about the amount. You cannot really opt out of the list.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT TAXES FUND

The federal income tax is progressive, which means higher income is taxed at higher rates. But here is the part everyone misses. The higher rate applies only to the dollars inside that bracket, not to all of your income.

Use round numbers. Say the first \$11,000 you earn is taxed at 10 percent, and everything from \$11,000 to \$45,000 is taxed at 12 percent. If you earn \$45,000, you do not pay 12 percent on all of it. You pay 10 percent on the first \$11,000, which is \$1,100, and 12 percent on the remaining \$34,000, which is \$4,080.

CHECKPOINT · HOW BRACKETS STACK

Which kills the myth. A raise that pushes you into a higher bracket only taxes the new dollars at the higher rate. Every dollar below the line keeps its old rate. Taking a raise always leaves you with more money. Always. If someone tells you otherwise, they are describing a system that does not exist.

CHECKPOINT · THE RAISE MYTH

Two more terms worth knowing. Your marginal tax rate is the rate on your next dollar, which is the bracket you are in. Your effective rate is what you actually paid across all your income, and it is always lower. In the example above you

paid \$5,180 on \$45,000, so your effective rate is about 11.5 percent even though your marginal rate is 12.

Finally, the standard deduction. Before any of this math runs, a chunk of your income is simply not taxed at all. For most students that means a summer job may owe nothing in federal income tax. If your employer withheld some anyway, filing a return is how you get it back.

File anyway, even when you do not have to. That is often free money sitting with the IRS waiting for you to ask.

Watch: The Sticker Price Is Not the Price

374 WORDS · ABOUT 2:30 SPOKEN

You look up a college and the website says \$58,000 a year. You close the tab. That reaction is understandable and it is also a mistake, because almost nobody pays that number.

That is the sticker price. The number that matters is the net price, which is sticker minus everything you do not have to pay back. Two students at the same school can pay wildly different amounts, and the expensive-looking private school is sometimes cheaper than the state school once aid lands.

CHECKPOINT · STICKER VS NET PRICE

Everything starts with one form, the FAFSA. It is free, it opens in the fall of your senior year, and it is the single door to federal grants, work-study, and federal loans. Many states and colleges also use it to decide their own aid. Skipping it because you assume you will not qualify is the most expensive assumption in this entire lesson. Fill it out. Every year.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT FAFSA UNLOCKS

What comes back is a menu, and the items are not equal. There is a golden order.

Grants first, because that is money you do not repay, usually based on financial need. Scholarships next, also free, usually based on something about you. Work-study third, because that is a job on campus with hours built around your class schedule. Then subsidized loans, where the government covers the interest while you are in school. Unsubsidized loans last, because those start charging interest the day the money arrives.

Take everything at the top of that list before you touch anything at the bottom.

CHECKPOINT · THE GOLDEN ORDER

Now compare offers properly. Two award letters can look similar and be nothing alike. School A: \$58,000 sticker, \$30,000 in grants, \$8,000 in loans, so you owe \$20,000 out of pocket and graduate \$8,000 in debt. School B: \$28,000 sticker, \$3,000 in grants, \$12,000 in loans, so you owe \$13,000 up front and graduate \$12,000 in debt. Cheaper today, more expensive later.

Do that math on paper for every offer. Also do not sleep on community college. Two years there and two at a state school can cut the total cost roughly in half, and your diploma says the school you graduated from.

Treat this like an investment, because it is one. What does the degree cost, and what does it realistically pay?

Watch: Start Embarrassingly Small

381 WORDS · ABOUT 2:32 SPOKEN

You do not need a degree, an office, or anybody's permission to start a business. Teenagers run real ones every day. Mowing lawns, tutoring algebra, designing logos, fixing phone screens. Entrepreneurship sounds enormous, and underneath it is just solving a problem for somebody and getting paid for it.

So start with the problem, not the idea. The best businesses come from noticing something annoying that people already deal with. Parents who cannot find a babysitter on short notice. Classmates who need a decent headshot. Neighbors with a yard nobody wants to touch. If you cannot name who is annoyed and what they are currently doing instead, you do not have a business yet.

CHECKPOINT · FINDING THE PROBLEM

Then there is one formula you cannot skip. Revenue minus costs equals profit.

Revenue is everything customers pay you. Costs are everything you spend to deliver it. Profit is what you actually keep, and it is the only number that matters. If you charge \$25 to mow a lawn and spend \$6 on gas, you made \$19, not \$25. Get that wrong and you can be busy every weekend and broke every month.

CHECKPOINT · REVENUE, COSTS, PROFIT

Pricing is where most people undercharge themselves into quitting. Too low and you are working for free and attracting customers who complain. Too high with no track record and nobody bites. Find the range by looking at what others charge, then price slightly under while you build up reviews, and raise it once you have proof you are good.

CHECKPOINT · PRICING

Two things to know before you scale. Reinvestment: when the money starts coming in, putting some back into better equipment or advertising is how a side hustle becomes an actual business instead of a hobby that pays. And taxes, because self-employed income is not withheld for you. If a client pays you more than \$600 in a year you may get a Form 1099, and either way that income is reportable. Set aside roughly a quarter of what you make and you will not get ambushed.

Last thing, and it is the most useful. Start embarrassingly small. Your first version should be almost too simple. One service, one price, five customers you already know. You learn more from five real customers in a month than from six months of planning a business you never launched.

Watch: "Get Rich Quick" Is Always the Tell

402 WORDS · ABOUT 2:41 SPOKEN

Your feed is full of it. Coins going to the moon, somebody your age in front of a rented Lamborghini, a betting app promising an easy parlay, a checkout button whispering four easy payments. Some of that is real technology. Some of it is gambling in a costume. Today is about telling them apart.

Cryptocurrency is digital money that is not issued by any government or bank. Instead of a bank keeping the records, transactions live on a blockchain, a shared public ledger copied across thousands of computers, which makes the record very hard to fake. The technology is genuinely clever. Here is the catch. Most crypto has no cash flow behind it. No rent, no profits, no interest. The price is purely what the next person will pay.

CHECKPOINT · WHAT CRYPTO ACTUALLY IS

Which brings up volatility, meaning how wildly a price swings. A savings account moves like a slow escalator. Insured, boring, always up. Crypto moves like an untested rollercoaster. Bitcoin has dropped more than 50 percent in a few months on multiple occasions, and plenty of smaller coins went to zero and stayed there.

So money you actually need, your emergency fund, car savings, college money, does not belong in something that can lose half its value before homecoming. Saving and speculating are different sports with different rules.

CHECKPOINT · VOLATILITY VS SAVING

Now the traps. A pump-and-dump is when insiders hype something to drive the price up, then sell their own holdings to the people who believed them, and the price collapses. If a stranger online is urgent about getting you in early, you are not early. You are the exit.

Betting apps and loot boxes work on a different principle called the house edge. The game is built so that over enough plays the house wins. Not usually, not mostly. Mathematically. You can win tonight. You cannot win forever.

CHECKPOINT · PUMP-AND-DUMP AND THE HOUSE EDGE

The last one is aimed straight at your brain. FOMO, the fear of missing out, is engineered into countdown timers and "only 3 left" banners and everyone else posting their wins and never their losses. Buy now, pay later is the same trick at checkout. Splitting a \$60 hoodie into four payments makes it feel free, and missed-payment fees can turn it into \$95.

One rule covers almost all of this. If it promises fast, guaranteed, or risk-free returns, it is selling you something. Real investing is slow and boring, and slow and boring is what actually works.